

SOP-RESP-1900: Respiratory Protection Program

Document owner: Occupational Health Department **Effective date:** 2024-03-05 **Review cycle:** 24 months

Section 1. Purpose and Scope

Governs selection, fit testing, and medical clearance for respiratory protection where engineering controls cannot reduce airborne hazard exposure below the applicable exposure limit.

Section 2. Medical Clearance

Clause 2.1 — Medical clearance from Occupational Health is required before initial respirator fit testing, and re-evaluated every 12 months or immediately if the employee reports a relevant health change.

Section 3. Fit Testing

Clause 3.1 — A tight-fitting respirator requires a passing quantitative or qualitative fit test on the specific make/model/size before use, repeated annually and whenever facial structure changes (significant weight change, dental work, facial scarring) or a different model is assigned.

Clause 3.2 — Facial hair intersecting the respirator sealing surface invalidates the fit test seal; an employee with such facial hair shall not use a tight-fitting respirator until it is removed.

Section 4. Selection

Clause 4.1 — Respirator selection (air-purifying vs. supplied-air, cartridge type) is based on the specific contaminant and its concentration relative to the cartridge's assigned protection factor — selection by a qualified person referencing the SDS and exposure monitoring data, not by the wearer's preference.

Clause 4.3 — An atmosphere that is IDLH (immediately dangerous to life or health), or of unknown concentration, requires supplied-air or SCBA; an air-purifying respirator is prohibited in either case.

Section 5. Cartridge Change-Out

Clause 5.1 — Cartridge change-out schedule is established from the contaminant's breakthrough data and use pattern, documented and posted at the point of use — not left to the wearer's judgment of when breakthrough odor is detected.

Section 6. Records

Clause 6.1 — Medical clearances and fit test records are filed to the Occupational Health File and retained for the duration of employment plus 30 years.